they were designated in the race-conscious corridors of South African sport. None of us within the squad was counting. I sincerely believe we were genuine new South Africans, blind to race and colour. As far as I was concerned, it was just the strongest possible team representing our country.

It was generally assumed the same team would be named to play in the semifinal. That was my expectation as captain, until I was called to a meeting at 5.30 pm on the evening before the match, half an hour before our usual team meeting was due to start, and was told Vernon Philander, who had passed his fitness test a few days earlier, would play instead of Kyle Abbott.

I knew about the Proteas convention that an incumbent player who is injured will automatically go back into the team when he returns to fitness, and Vern was an incumbent. Vernon and Dale had been our regular opening bowlers and were earmarked to lead our first-choice attack and I sensed the selectors thought Vernon would thrive in New Zealand conditions. Even so, it seemed to me, there could have been other considerations.

We had been assured that Cricket South Africa was the only national sporting governing body in the country that had declined to set a target for the number of players of colour to be included in the national team, but there was a delicate balance to be struck and it was generally understood that, as they chose the side, the national selectors would be conscious of working towards providing opportunities for at least four players of colour.

So what had happened? Had Vernon, who was officially classified as coloured, been selected ahead of Kyle, who was classified as white, to ensure there were four players of colour in our team for the semifinal? Or had the decision been made for purely cricketing reasons?

It depressed me even to think of my teammates in these outdated racial terms, as white or coloured, but three players of colour had played